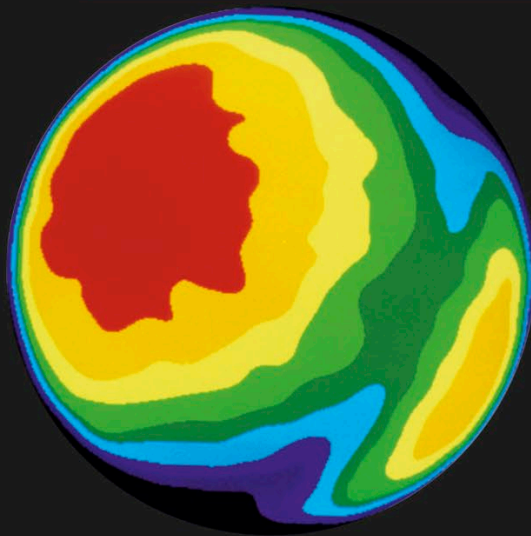


Red hot

As Mercury faces the Sun, temperatures reach a sizzling 427°C (800°F), hot enough to melt lead. Mercury is the second-hottest planet, after Venus.



This false colour picture of planet Mercury, taken by *MESSENGER*, is used to show the geological features of the planet.

This is a temperature map of Mercury – red shows where the most heat is found.

A small planet

Mercury is the smallest planet in the solar system. Pluto, which is smaller, has been reclassified as a dwarf planet.



Cross-section of Mercury, showing its iron core.

Long journey

Launched in 2004, space probe *MESSENGER* set out on a journey to Mercury. It reached the planet in 2008, flew by three times, and then entered Mercury's orbit in 2011. By 2013, it had mapped its entire surface.

